7.1 What is an object store?

Back in the old days, data was managed in a hierarchy consisting of folders and files. The file was the representation of the data. In an *object store*, data is stored as objects. Each object consists of a globally unique identifier, some metadata, and the data itself, as figure 7.1 illustrates. An object's *globally unique identifier* (GUID) is also known as its *key*; you can address the object from different devices and machines in a distributed system using the GUID.

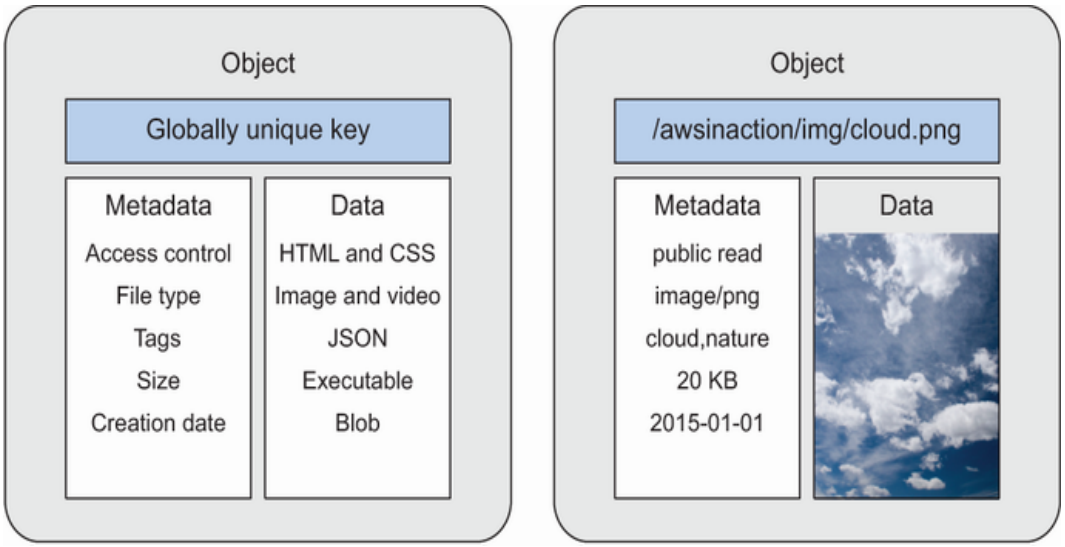


Figure 7.1 Objects stored in an object store have three parts: a unique ID, metadata describing the content, and the content itself (such as an image).

Typical examples for object metadata are:

- Date of last modification
- Object size
- Object's owner
- Object's content type

It is possible to request only an object's metadata without requesting the data itself. This is useful if you want to list objects and their metadata before accessing a specific object's data.